Unit-Level AI Usage Framework Packet

Companion to the NAU Tech Summit 2026 talk "Unit-Level AI Usage Frameworks for Departments and Programs, Built to Scale." Blue Brazelton, October 20, 2026. Six pages: audit, starter framework, big swing, unit menu, worked example, scaling up. Online at bluebrazelton.com/unit-framework.

This packet is a starting structure, not policy. NAU policy settles whether a tool may be used and with what data; your unit framework settles how. Where the two seem to disagree, NAU policy and the ITS Service Catalog win.

Page 1. Audit: what does our guidance tell an office like ours?

Take three minutes. For each item, read NAU's public guidance and mark whether it tells your office what to do: Yes, Partly, or It stops here. The items where it stops are where your unit framework starts.

#	Item	The question for your office	Yes / Partly / Stops
1	Approved tools	Which AI tools may our office use, and with which data level?	
2	Data rules	What may and may not go into an AI tool?	
3	Disclosure	When and how do we say that a tool was used?	
4	Who to ask	Who answers a question the guidance does not?	
5	What's off-limits	What work should the tool never touch?	

Where to look (NAU public guidance, checked October 2026)

- ITS: AI and the NAU Acceptable Use Policy (use NAU credentials for university AI work; sensitive data never goes into unapproved or personal accounts).
- ITS: Approved AI Tools at NAU (which tools are approved, and the rule that when a tool's permitted data level is unclear, use Level 1 public data only).
- Information Security Services: Data Classification and Handling policy (Level 1 Public, Level 2 Internal, Level 3 Sensitive, Level 4 Highly Sensitive; revised February 11, 2026).
- Office of the Provost: Artificial intelligence resources (guidance for students, faculty, and staff users).
- Which data level each approved tool may handle is listed in the ITS Service Catalog. Note that NAU's pages differ on the ceiling (one says nothing above Level 2 into generative AI; another says an enterprise account may handle Levels 1–3), so check the catalog entry for the specific tool and, when unclear, stay at Level 1.

Page 2. Starter unit framework (one page)

One task per framework. Answer the four questions, name an owner, set a review date, and keep a change log. Four honest rows are a framework; a long document is a memo nobody reads.

Field	Your answer
Unit	
Task (the big swing)	
Effective: does the tool do this specific job well? How did we test it (for example, on ten before three hundred)? What counts as a pass?	
Efficient: is the time saved real after we count the checking? What do we compare it against, and when do we stop?	
Ethical: what data may the tool see? What data goes in; what is excluded (names, identifiers, anything Level 3 or above unless the ITS Service Catalog allows it for this tool); who checks before anything goes in; who to ask.	
Excellent: is the result good enough to carry our unit's name? What does the deliverable look like, who signs off, and what is the one-line disclosure?	
Owner (one person)	
Review date (start of each term is a good default)	
Change log (version, date, what changed, why)	

Four questions in the spirit of NAU 2025 – Elevating Excellence. The four E's are a working device for this packet, not language from the plan.

Page 3. Pick your big swing

A big swing is an overdue, useful project that is low-stakes if it stalls and built on information that is already public or easy to strip of names. It is not the tool answering your email or writing your reports. Run your candidates through three filters:

1. Impactful: people would notice if it got done.
2. Overdue: it has rolled to the next to-do list more than twice.
3. Low-stakes if it stalls: nothing breaks if the experiment fails.

For individual contributors, the signal is different: the task you avoid because it needs a skill you do not have yet (the idea needs Python and you do not know Python). That is exactly where a productivity tool earns its place.

Five-minute team-meeting script for leaders (Monday)

1. Minute 1. “What is the potentially impactful project, task, or function we keep putting off or rolling from one to-do list to the next?” Write every answer down; do not evaluate yet.
2. Minute 2. Ask the three filters out loud for each answer. Keep the ones that pass all three.
3. Minute 3. For each survivor, ask: “What information would a tool need to see to help with this?” If the honest answer includes names, student records, personnel files, or anything you would not email outside the office, mark it and move on.
4. Minute 4. Pick one. Name an owner. Agree the first thing the owner will write is the ethical row on page 2.
5. Minute 5. Set the review date and put the framework somewhere the whole team can see it. Say when you will look at it again.

Say it as a productivity tool, not a colleague: “we are going to try a tool on this” rather than “we are going to ask the AI.” It keeps the decision, and the responsibility, with the people in the room.

Page 4. Unit menu: sixteen offices, one big swing each

Examples, not assignments. Swap in your own. The data note names what the ethical row would have to settle first, using NAU's Data Classification and Handling levels (Level 1 Public, Level 2 Internal, Level 3 Sensitive, Level 4 Highly Sensitive). Confirm the level with ITS before anything above Level 1 goes into a tool.

Unit	Big swing	Data note
Human Resources	Rewrite a department's position descriptions into one consistent, plain-language format, checked against a skills framework	Level 1–2 (position descriptions). Keep personnel files out entirely.
Academic Advising	Turn catalog requirements into a one-page visual map for every major the office advises	Level 1 (public catalog).
Athletics	Turn the season's rule and compliance updates into a short staff digest with a “what changes for us” column	Level 1 (public rules). No student-athlete records.
Parking & Transportation	Analyze a few years of shuttle ridership by route and hour, and draft a schedule proposal with charts for the committee	Level 1–2 (aggregate counts). No permit-holder data.
Campus Life / Event Programming	The running example: scanned paper event evaluations, analyzed, written up as a findings brief	Level 2–3: redact names and identifying comments before anything is scanned.
Housing & Residence Life	Turn the RA training binder into short scenario-based modules	Level 1–2 (training content). No incident reports.
Financial Aid & Scholarships	Rewrite the most-asked award questions into a plain-language FAQ, with a Spanish version reviewed by a fluent staff member	Level 1 (public policy text). No student aid records.
IT Services / Help Desk	Group a year of ticket categories (no names) and draft the 20 self-help articles that would prevent the most tickets	Level 2–3: strip requester information first.
Facilities	Sort the work-order backlog by building and type into a prioritized maintenance memo	Level 1–2 (operational data).
Admissions & Recruitment	Adapt one campus-visit presentation into versions for first-generation families, transfer students, and parents	Level 1 (public content).
Career Services	Compare a term's public job postings in the region against what the office's workshops cover, and spot the gaps	Level 1 (public postings).
Assessment / Institutional Research	Have the tool write the Python that rebuilds the annual report's tables every year (the “I don't know Python” example)	Level 2–3: build and test on synthetic or de-identified data.
Department / Dean's Office Staff	Consolidate scattered process emails and old memos into one procedures manual for the office	Level 1–2: check for personnel or student details first.
Marketing & Communications	Retrofit alt text and plain-language summaries across a backlog of web pages	Level 1 (public pages).
Disability Resources	Turn the staff-facing accommodations guide into a searchable FAQ	Level 1 (public guide). Never individual accommodation records.
Budget / Business Office	Draft first-pass variance explanations from a summary report for the director to edit	Level 3–4: confirm the data tier with ITS before any figures leave the office.

Page 5. Worked example: paper event evaluations

The task: events end, paper evaluations come back (people complete paper more readily than a link), and the stack sits because someone has to do the data entry. The workflow: scan the forms, have the tool extract ratings and comments into a table, analyze them, and produce a one-page findings brief. Here is the framework that makes that workflow safe to build, in work order (ethical first).

Row	Decision for this task
Ethical (first)	Before scanning, redact the name and email lines and any comment that identifies a person. Rating boxes and general comments go in. Treat the redacted batch as Level 1–2; confirm the tool's permitted level in the ITS Service Catalog. One named staff member checks the redaction on every form before scanning.
Effective	Test on ten forms before three hundred. Compare the ten extracted rows against the ten paper forms side by side. Pass means every rating matches and every comment is complete, including the one half in the margin. Fail means fix the setup or stop.
Efficient	Time the hand-entry baseline on ten forms. Time the tool plus the checking on the same ten. The checking counts. If checking takes as long as typing, stop; that is the framework working, not failing.
Excellent	The deliverable is a one-page findings-and-recommendations brief the director can forward, with one line at the bottom: “Ratings and comments were extracted from scanned forms with an AI tool and checked by staff.” Disclosure is normal professional practice, like citing a source.
Owner / review / change log	Owner: the program coordinator. Review: start of each term. Change log: v1, October 2026, first draft.

Page 6. Scaling up (optional): from three unit frameworks to one for the college or division

The same four rows work at every level. Read policy down: the institution settles whether and with what data; the college or division settles shared rows; the unit settles its task; the task settles one decision per E. Fold practice up: when three units in a college have written frameworks, the rows they share are a college framework waiting to happen.

How to fold up

1. Lay the three unit frameworks side by side, one row at a time.
2. Where the ethical rows agree (for example, “names and identifiers out before anything goes in; Level 1–2 only unless the catalog says otherwise”), lift that sentence into the college framework as a shared rule.
3. Where the effective and efficient rows differ, leave them at the unit level. They are task-specific by design.
4. Keep the excellent row's disclosure line shared; it is the one sentence every deliverable in the college should carry.
5. Give the college framework its own owner, review date, and change log. The unit frameworks keep theirs.

What scales and what does not

Scale the intention, not the solution. What travels up or down is the goal and what the first unit learned getting there. The first unit's specific tool, prompt, or workflow usually does not transfer, and forcing it is how a college framework turns into a memo. A college or division framework that fits on one page, with rows that three units actually agreed on, will outlast any tool named in it.

Questions: Blue Brazelton, blue.brazelton@gmail.com. This packet is the pilot of a longer version being built for a December 2026 web tool; feedback on what was missing is welcome.